INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE MUMBAI

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When in Mumbai, expect fireworks. They were aplenty on October 4 and 5 at the India Today Conclave Mumbai, beginning with Maharashtra deputy chief minister Devendra Fadnavis declaring that Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) president Sharad Pawar had in 2019 consented to the imposition of President's Rule in the state, when the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) had tried to form the government. Pawar took to stage later in the day to reassert that he would not join the BJP and stood firmly on INDIA's side. But this was just the beginning—the verbal pyrotechnics at the conclave went far beyond politics.

Other hot topics included the India vs Bharat controversy, appropriating Ambedkar, 100 years of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), and the Uniform Civil Code (UCC). On the UCC, BJP's Rajya Sabha MP Sushil Modi suggested that tribals be kept outside of it, while AIMIM Lok Sabha MP Asaduddin Owaisi said a UCC goes against the nation's ethos of "pluralism and diversity".

When in the country's financial capital, can conversations on India's financial landscape be far behind? Uday Kotak, founder, Kotak Mahindra Bank, praised the way our country navigated the Covid-19 years and handled the geopolitical situation arising out of the Russia-Ukraine war. However, he also asked pertinent questions, like 'Why is it that corporate India is not able to compete with China?'

Two women scientists, Dr Annapurni Subramaniam and Nigar Shaji, who are at the forefront of the Aditya Solar Mission, spoke about breaking the glass ceiling in a male-dominated field. "I always tell women don't doubt yourself. If you are confident, just go ahead and do it," said Subramaniam to much applause.


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On the entertainment front, filmmakers Vishal Bhardwaj and Sujoy Ghosh and actors Vijay Varma, Wamiqa Gabbi and Jaideep Ahlawat spoke about how OTT platforms offer meaty opportunities to both writers and talented actors, making stars out of them. Meanwhile, actress Uorfi Javed left the audience stunned with her unapologetic stance on her sartorial choices. The cast of Netflix's *The Archies* also spoke about their characters.

Mental health came under focus too, first in a session on student suicides, followed by a chat with actress Rhea Chakraborty, who highlighted how mental health woes remain misunderstood. The actress was giving her first interview in nearly three years.

With the nation gripped by cricket fever, the conclave also saw former World Cup winners Sunil Gavaskar and Harbhajan Singh discuss India's prospects of winning on home soil again. Singh was optimistic that the Men in Blue would make the cut for semis. "After that, it comes down to some luck as well," he said. There was some valuable advice for the players too: stay away from social media, and avoid phones. ■

Suhani Singh